

Genre Criticism: The Stabilization of Romantasy

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The romantasy genre has exploded over the last decade. This specific new genre has dominated the literary industry, social media, bestselling lists, and reader intrigue. Writer's Digest defines romantasy as a "blending of romance and fantasy in a way that... often requires that your protagonist's characterization hinge upon their relationship with a love interest" ("What Is Romantasy, Anyway?"). New York bestselling novels such as *A Court of Thorns and Roses* by Sarah J. Maas and *Fourth Wing* by Rebecca Yarros are both popular examples of how this genre can function and gain popularity within the media. If we approach this genre through the lens of Ted Underwood's genre criticism, we can discern that romantasy is moving toward stabilization through recurring formal conventions, online reader communities such as BookTok, and hybrid genre patterns that reflect Underwood's argument that genres can develop stable coherence over time rather than being short-lived (Underwood).

The romantasy genre was not created from a completely new idea, but rather from a combination of fantasy and romance themes. Romance narratives have existed for centuries, originally centering on emotional relationships and evolving over time through authors such as Jane Austen and the Brontë sisters, who helped shape more idealized portrayals of love. Fantasy similarly has deep roots in myths, legends, and stories involving magic or supernatural elements. Over time, these two genres naturally merged, creating early fantasy-romance hybrids such as *Phantastes* by George MacDonald and later works like *Beauty* by Robin McKinley. Although the label "romantasy" is relatively new, its literary foundations are much older. This longer history supports Ted Underwood's argument that genres often develop through gradual evolution rather

than brief cultural trends, suggesting that romantasy may be entering a phase of long-term stabilization rather than temporary popularity. (McAlister and Cuthbert)

Another reason to believe that the romantasy genre could be considered a stabilized genre is its patterns of aesthetics, themes, style, and repeated tropes that keep the genre current and alive. To better understand these patterns and structures within romantasy, it is important to examine what these stories look like. We will be looking at two very popular romantasy novels that are circulating through the media today. The first romantasy novel in which we can recognize these patterns is *A Court of Thorns and Roses* by Sarah J. Maas. This novel focuses on fantasy world-building, with fictional elements such as fairies, magic, and mythical creatures. We also see a great deal of political corruption in the story, adding elements of conflict through the world's class structure. Multiple romantic tropes also drive the characters' choices throughout the story, such as enemies to lovers and forbidden love. The story is told through an emotional first-person point of view. Another highly successful novel in this genre is *Fourth Wing* by Rebecca Yarros. Much like in *A Court of Thorns and Roses*, there is fantastical world-building, political intrigue and corruption, and repeating tropes such as enemies to lovers and forbidden love. All of these repeating themes, styles, and aesthetics show that this genre is structured and established, suggesting the potential for long-term stability through recognizable patterns.

A reason that the romantasy genre has gained popularity is not just through publishing and marketing fields, but because of the growth of social media communities that review and identify the romantasy genre. One of these communities is the BookTok literary community found on the platform TikTok (Wheatley). Book and literary influencers take the lead in this community, with a focus on reviews and recommendations. The visual nature of seeing people

passionate about specific genres has helped drive this community's growth. What has made this specific genre grow more than others are the hashtags that bring traction and allow people to promote romantasy works. Hashtags that surround the romantasy genre in this community include #romantasy, #ACOTAR, and #fantasyromance ("Best #Romantasy Hashtags"). These hashtags bring people to videos who are looking for a novel or book within the romantasy genre. This online community also creates expectations for the genre by using similar, repeated words or phrases such as morally gray MMC, spice, and enemies to lovers (Wheatley). This happens because influencers within the BookTok community discuss specific reasons to read these books, highlighting particular aesthetics that lead readers to develop these expectations for the genre. Another way people create these expectations is through the platform Goodreads. This application and website demonstrate reader-led genre creation because, in reviews of books like *A Court of Thorns and Roses* and *Fourth Wing*, readers themselves label these books as romantasy ("Romantasy Books"). This is an example of how social media communities and readers help label and create genre rather than publishers or writers themselves.

Some people might even argue that romantasy is simply a temporary BookTok-driven or Goodreads trend, but the evidence suggests otherwise. Underwood argues that some genres develop stronger coherence over time through repeated structures and audience recognition (Underwood). Romantasy appears to be following this pattern, as its consistent themes, reader identification, and growing popularity suggest movement toward long-term genre stabilization rather than decline. Although this does not mean the genre will remain unchanged, romantasy is already beginning to fragment into smaller subcategories such as cozy romantasy, dark romantasy, and epic romantasy works ("Cozy, Epic, and Dark Romantasy Audiobooks"). This fragmentation is not necessarily a sign of the end of romantasy as a whole, but rather evidence of

genre growth. As publishers and writers continue to explore romantasy titles, and digital communities continue shaping reader expectations, the genre will likely become more widely known.

To conclude, romantasy may appear to be another social media-driven literary trend, but its history, repeated structures, and growing reader discussion surrounding the genre suggest that it is something that will last longer. Through Ted Underwood's lens of genre criticism, romantasy appears less temporary and more like a genre entering a phase of stabilization. Although the genre will likely continue evolving into smaller subcategories and new forms, that evolution itself reflects growth (Underwood). Romantasy ultimately demonstrates how modern genres are no longer shaped solely by authors or publishers, but by digital communities and readers who are constantly defining them.

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